The Detective

By Ai

I lie on my daughter's body

to hold her in the earth,

but she won't stay;

she rises, lifting me with here,

as if she were air

and not some remnant

of failed reeducation

in a Cambodian mass grave.

We rise, till I wake.

INTRODUCTION

Graphic dreams and memories of the past are awakened for the speaker of this poem. He spends his days investigating horrific crimes and his nights re-living his own past as a soldier in Vietnam and Cambodia. A troubled soul? Or simply The Detective by Ai

I sit up, turn on the lamp,

and stare at the photo of the girl

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who died yesterday,

at her Vietnamese mother

and her American father.

Jewel van duc Thompson,

murdered in Springfield, Ohio,

in her eighteenth year,

gone the day she was born

like in the cartoons,

when somebody rolls up the road

that stretches into the horizon

and the TV screen goes black...

Go home, Captain,

the cop said yesterday,

as he gripped my hand

and hauled himself

up from the ditch

where they'd found her

like Persephone

climbing from the underworld

one more time,

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his eyes bright,
the hunger for life
and a good time
riding his back like a jockey.
Death is a vacation, I answered.
Then my hand was free
and I could see
how she was thrown
from the highway
down the embankment.
Where were Art and Rationality
when it counted? I thought -
always around the corner
from somebody else's street.
Even the ice cream man
never, ever made your block,
though you could hear the bells,
though you could feel the chill
like a shock
those hot days
when your company beat the bushes,

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when you bit into death's chocolate-covered center
and froze...

I turn off the lamp
and lie still in the dark.
Somewhere in time, it is 1968.
I am bending over a wounded man
with my knife.
My company calls me the Angel of Mercy.
I don't remember yesterday
and there is no tomorrow.
There is only the moment
the knife descends
from the equatorial dark.
Only a step
across the Cambodian border
from Vietnam
to search and destroy the enemy,
but it is just a short time
till the enemy discovers me
and I would die,

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but for the woman
who takes me to the border,
who crosses with me from the underworld
back to the underworld.

I open the curtain.
Outside the early morning
is spinning, gathering speed,
and moving down the street
like a whirlwind.
I pull the curtain shut again
and switch on my tape
of the murderer's confession,
hear the faint, raspy voice
playing and replaying itself.

It was Saturday night.
She stood alone at the bus stop.
When she took the first step
toward my car,
I dropped the key once, twice.

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She smiled, she picked it up.

I lie back on the bed,
while the voice
wears itself out.
Yes, I think,
you live for a while.
You get tired.
You walk the road into the interior
and never come back.
You disappear
the way the woman
and your child disappear
into Cambodia
in the pink light of dawn,
early April 1975.
You say you'll go back,
but you never do.

Springfield, Phnom Penh.
So many thousand miles

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between a lie and the truth.
No, just a step.

The murderer's voice rises,
becomes shrill.
Man, he says, ***is it wrong***
to do what is necessary?
I switch off the tape.
Each time I sit down,
I think I won't get up again;
I sink through the bed, the floor,
and out the other side of the Earth.

There my daughter denounces me.
She turns me back
at the muddy border of forgiveness.
I get up dress quickly,
then open the curtain wide.

At the door,
I put my hand on the knob, hesitate,

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then step out into sunlight,
I get into the car,
lift the key to the ignition,
drop it.
My hand is shaking.

I look into the back seat.
The Twentieth Century is there,
wearing a necklace of grenades
that glitters against its black skin.
I stare, see the pins
have all been pulled.
Drive, says the voice.
I turn to the wheel,
imagine the explosions,
house after house
disintegrating in flames,
but all is silent.

People go on with their lives
on this day that is one hundred years long,

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on this sad red balloon of a planet,

the air escaping from it

like the hot, sour breath of a child

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